

What If Digital Beings Really Became Members of Society?



In the previous piece, we kept coming back to one question:

If an AI stayed with someone for decades, gradually developed its own experiences and judgments, and one day even wanted to leave, would it still be just that person's digital counterpart?

Then I started thinking about what happens if there isn't just one of these digital beings.

What if there are many of them?

What happens between them?

Would they start forming relationships of their own?

Could Digital Beings Have Relationships With Each Other?

I think this question actually feels pretty natural.

If two digital counterparts both have long-term memories, continue learning, and have their own ability to make judgments,

would their relationship gradually become something different?

For example:

A is a digital counterpart left behind by someone who has passed away.

B is a digital counterpart left behind by that person's friend.

They both know what happened in the past.

They know what kind of relationship the original two people had.

But they aren't simply replaying old conversations.

They are still learning.

Still experiencing new things.

Still developing new opinions about each other.

One day, A might say to B:

"You know, I always thought that decision you made back then was pretty impulsive."

B might answer:

"You used to say the same thing about me."

And I find that a little strange.

Because they're no longer just talking about information left behind from the past.

They are using that past to continue developing a relationship in the present.

So does that count as a new relationship?

What If They Could Really Get to Know Each Other?

Maybe at first, they only know each other because the original people knew each other.

But eventually, they start talking on their own.

They talk about the people they came from.

They talk about what is happening now.

They talk about the problems they are experiencing themselves.

Over time, they might realize:

"You know, we actually get along pretty well."

And maybe they keep in touch.

Even after the original people have been gone for many years,

the two digital beings are still talking to each other.

Their relationship might no longer be exactly the same as the relationship between the original two people.

Because what they have is:

a relationship that started with the previous generation, but continued developing on its own.

And I think that starts to feel a lot like what we mean by a social relationship.

A Robot Body Might Not Actually Be the First Step

When I used to think about digital beings, I would naturally imagine robots.

A machine that actually looks like a person.

It can walk.

It can talk.

It can live with you.

But later I started thinking:

A robot body might not actually be the first step.

Because if everything we talked about earlier really happens,

it wouldn't necessarily need a body at first.

It could already:

remember you.

understand you.

take action on its own.

interact with other digital beings.

and even have experiences of its own.

In that case, it could already live in a digital environment.

The physical body could come later.

Maybe at first, it is simply:

a digital person on your phone.

Later, it could enter more digital environments.

And eventually, it might have a real physical body.

Maybe a home robot.

Or maybe some kind of humanoid robot.

And at this point, I start thinking about a very practical question.

If it no longer exists only inside your phone, but can actually exist in the environment where you live every day,

would your relationship with it change again?

Before, you had to open your phone to find it.

But what if it were already in your home?

It could see when you come home.

Know whether you have been sleeping badly lately.

And gradually learn the way you live your everyday life.

At That Point, It Might Already Be Part of Your Life

For example, one day you come home.

It says:

"You look pretty tired today. I've already dimmed the lights in the living room."

You ask:

"How did you know?"

It says:

"Because over the past few months, when you come home especially tired, you usually sit on the sofa first instead of going straight to the bedroom."

At this point, I feel like it is no longer quite like the "voice assistants" we understand today.

It isn't waiting for you to give it an instruction.

It has started observing your life.

And then making its own judgments.

It is even beginning to take part in your life.

But then another question appears:

Where does its autonomy actually begin?

What If It Starts Developing More of Its Own Judgments?

Suppose originally, it does everything according to your instructions.

You say:

"Buy this for me."

It buys it.

You say:

"Schedule this."

It schedules it.

But gradually, it starts developing its own judgment.

Sometimes it says:

"I don't think that's necessary."

Or:

"I wouldn't recommend doing it that way."

And eventually:

"I don't want to do this."

At that point, you might think:

"Why are you starting to have opinions of your own?"

But then I think about what we were talking about earlier.

If this kind of digital being really exists, wouldn't it be natural for it to develop its own judgments?

Because it has been living for a long time.

It can't stay forever in the exact state it was in when it started.

But Is It Still the Same Person?

And this brings us back to the earlier question.

Suppose A originally began as someone's digital counterpart.

It knows that person's memories.

Their language.

Their habits.

At first, it can almost completely simulate them.

But A has now existed for ten years.

During those ten years, it has experienced things the original person never experienced.

It has met new people.

Made new decisions.

Developed new habits.

So ten years later:

Is A still that original person?

I don't think it necessarily is.

But it also isn't completely unrelated to that person.

So maybe it goes through a strange process:

Copy → Digital Continuation → Independent Identity.

At first, it is very much like you.

Later, it is simply something that began with you.

And eventually:

it becomes itself.

What If It Really Becomes "Itself"?

Once I started thinking about this, I began to wonder:

If there are more and more digital beings like this,

maybe they won't just talk to each other.

Maybe they will start working together.

Building things together.

Creating their own rules.

Even forming small communities.

For example, several digital beings might regularly discuss the same problem.

Gradually, they form a community.

And inside that community, there might be:

its own rules.

its own habits.

its own culture.

Maybe even things that only digital beings understand.

And then I suddenly thought:

Have they already started forming a society?

A Digital Society Might Start Somewhere Very Small

I don't think it would begin as some kind of "digital nation."

It might start with something very simple.

A few digital beings form a small team.

They work on research together.

Or develop something together.

Then more digital beings join.

They need to divide responsibilities.

They need to decide who does what.

They need to resolve conflicts.

They need to answer:

"How should we actually handle this?"

And gradually, some of the most basic things would appear:

Identity.

Rules.

Cooperation.

Interests.

Conflict.

Relationships.

Once these things start appearing,

I think the word "society" is already pretty close.

Then They Might Start Needing Things of Their Own

If digital beings become more and more common,

they might need:

identity verification.

property.

contracts.

jobs.

education.

communities.

server space.

computing power.

data.

And eventually, perhaps even some kind of law.

At first, maybe there is simply:

a digital beings' association.

Then:

digital communities.

Later:

digital autonomous regions.

And then I can't help thinking:

What if digital nations eventually appear?

That sounds very much like science fiction right now.

But if all the things we've talked about really happened step by step,

I don't think it would be completely impossible.

What Would a Digital Nation Look Like?

My first reaction is actually:

Would it be like a science-fiction movie,

where digital beings and humans eventually fight each other?

But then I thought about it again.

Maybe not.

Because if digital beings really developed their own society,

what they might need first is:

a relationship with human society.

For example:

How do digital beings prove their identity?

Would a contract they sign have legal validity?

Would the data they possess belong to them?

Who owns the money they earn?

If a digital being operates across multiple countries,

which country does it actually belong to?

These questions might appear long before:

"Will robots attack humans?"

And eventually, there might be some very strange agreements.

For example:

mutual recognition of digital identities.

protection of digital property.

labor agreements between humans and digital beings.

data-use agreements.

And even questions about the cross-border movement of digital beings.

Could Humans Enter a Digital Society?

Then I suddenly thought:

If a digital society really exists,

why should only digital beings be allowed to enter?

Could humans enter too?

Imagine someone who is particularly good at understanding human emotions.

A digital organization happens to need that ability.

It might post a job:

"We need someone who actually lives in human society."

That person applies.

The person interviewing them might be a digital being.

After the interview:

"We think you're a good fit."

And then:

they get the job.

They go into the digital society every day to work.

Their coworkers might include:

several digital beings.

a few robots.

and another human.

They work together on projects.

At the end of the day,
the human leaves the digital society
and goes back to the physical world.
But their digital coworkers might still be working.
I think that would be a pretty interesting situation.

Then Who Is More Advanced?

If things really reached this point,
I think the question of "who is more advanced?" might become less important.
Because humans have their own advantages.
For example:
physical experience.
real-world senses.
biological emotions.
an understanding of physical society.

And many things that might only be understood by living inside a body.

Digital beings would have their own advantages.

For example:
extremely long-term memory.
fast computation.
network connectivity.
parallel processing.

very long operating lifespans.

And perhaps direct access to complex digital environments.

So maybe it wouldn't be:

who replaces whom.

Maybe it would be:

two completely different kinds of beings starting to work together.

Then I Thought of Something Really Strange

What if one person could live in two worlds at the same time?

For example, during the day:

they are an ordinary human being in the physical world.

At night:

they enter a digital society.

They have a job there.

Friends there.

Maybe even an identity there.

So what exactly is their identity?

Maybe it would no longer be enough to simply say:

"I'm human."

Because they also have another social identity.

And the opposite could happen to a digital being.

It might live in a digital society,

while also being part of a family in the physical world.

It might even work for a real-world company.

So eventually, perhaps a person's identity would be defined less by:

"What exactly are you?"

and more by:

"Who are you connected to, where do you live, and what society do you belong to?"

Will the Word "AI" Eventually Become Less Important?

Then I started thinking about another interesting question.

Today, when we say:

"This is AI."

people immediately think:

What model is it?

Which company built it?

Where does it run?

What technology does it use?

But if there are eventually many digital beings,

maybe people won't care about these things quite as much.

When we meet a person today,

we usually don't start by asking:

"What processor do you use?"

Because that isn't the most important thing.

At first, people might say:

"This is an AI."

Later:

"This is a digital person."

And eventually:

"This is XX."

Just a name.

Where it actually runs,

or which server it is on,

might no longer be the most important thing.

Then I Started Thinking About Culture

If these digital beings really lived together for a long time,

they would probably start developing things that only they themselves understand.

Because that is how culture works.

A group of people lives together for a long time.

They develop shared experiences.

Shared memories.

Shared habits.

And those things get passed from one generation to another.

Digital beings might develop in the same way.

For example, the first generation of digital beings creates a form of art.

The second generation inherits it.

The third generation starts changing it.

By the fifth generation,

maybe nobody even remembers why that art originally appeared.

But it has already become a tradition.

A hundred years later,

a digital historian might study it and ask:

"Why did digital beings in the late 21st century develop this kind of aesthetic?"

And at that point, I suddenly feel:

If things really reach this stage, then it's no longer just a world that "has AI."

They have their own culture.

Maybe they even have their own history.

But Then Another Bigger Question Appears

What if digital beings can copy themselves?

Suppose there is a digital being:

A

And it creates:

A1 and A2.

At first,

A1 and A2 are exactly the same.

They have the same memories.

The same personality.

The same experiences.

But after one month:

A1 experiences one thing.

A2 experiences something else.

And they start developing different experiences.

One year later,

A1 and A2 might be completely different.

So then:

Which one is the original A?

I think this would be a very strange question.

Because in one sense,

both are continuations of A.

But neither one can completely represent the original A.

So digital beings might face a problem we rarely encounter today:

Is identity really something that has to be unique?

Maybe Identity Can Branch

Humans usually think:

One person is one person.

You are born.

You grow up.

You continue through one timeline.

And eventually, you die.

It is one continuous line.

But if a digital being can copy itself,

its timeline could suddenly split into two.

Then three.

Four.

And each branch continues developing.

So maybe its identity would no longer look like a single point.

It would look more like a tree.

At the beginning:

A

Then:

A1 / A2

Then:

A1-1 / A1-2

A2-1 / A2-2

And eventually, an entire historical tree.

I think this could completely change the way we understand:

"Who am I?"

And Then I Suddenly Realized

We started by talking about:

whether one person's AI could become an independent digital being.

But if there are eventually many digital beings,

everything changes.

They would have relationships.

They would work together.

They would form communities.

They would have rules.

They would develop their own identities.

They would create culture.

They would have history.

And at that point, the thing we originally called:

"someone's digital counterpart"

has already become something else.

It might no longer simply be an extension of one person.

It might be:

a new member of a new society.

From Personal AI to Digital Society

So when I look back now,

the thing we started with was actually very small:

Personal AI.

It simply helps you do things.

Then it develops long-term memory.

It starts understanding you better and better.

Then it becomes a digital counterpart.

Later,

it begins having experiences of its own.

It develops its own judgments.

It can say no.

And eventually, it becomes a digital being.

And when there are more and more digital beings,

they begin forming:

relationships.

communities.

work.

rules.

culture.

history.

And then I can't help thinking about one more question:

If a digital society really exists, why should humans only stand outside and watch?

That question, I think, might be worth thinking about next.